The bar mitzvah

A small crowd of party activists, many barely out of their teens, clustered around the stage, dancing awkwardly to the pumping music. A boyish, smiling Herzog and a stern Livni stared down from the Jumbotron, superimposed on a fluttering Israeli flag. Bored and exhausted journalists mobbed the concession stand for $5 hot dogs, waiting for the guests of honor to arrive.

The Zionist Camp's election-night party, at a mostly empty sports arena in Tel Aviv, felt more like a low-rent bar mitzvah than the coronation of a new prime minister.

There were hints, throughout the day, that the coronation might not even take place. Down in the south, in the Likud strongholds, voters were holding their noses and casting ballots for Netanyahu. You could spot them immediately: they admitted to doing the deed, then rushed away when asked why, seemingly embarrassed by their actions. Outside a polling station in Ashdod, the pavement littered with mock ballots for Likud, Natan Ben Dror lit a cigarette and pondered what he'd done. "I don't know why I did it, really," he admitted. "I guess because I'm a Likudnik," the Hebrew word for a Likud supporter.

It was the same in Sderot, despite the skepticism I had encountered on a trip to the city just a few days earlier. None of their explanations were enthusiastic. "*He's a strong man*." "*I always vote Likud*." "*Who else would I vote for?*" But they did it, nonetheless. Some pointed to their phones, to the text messages warning them about the "droves", the mythical high Arab turnout. "We need a right-wing government, or Buji (Herzog) is going to let the Arabs run wild in the Knesset," said Dvir Amar, a student.

"This part of the country, it's a right-wing place," said Moshe Solomon, an Ethiopian Jew working as a security guard outside a Sderot polling station. "The people don't like him. But they'll do it anyway." Some of them, at least. Solomon, another Likudnik, hadn't made up his mind about whether to vote yet. "Maybe after work," he laughed.

Even in the settlements, where voters lean further to the right, it seemed many were acceding to Netanyahu's request that they "come home" to Likud.

There was equally no last-minute surge toward Herzog. Polling places in Tel Aviv and the kibbutzim, the bastions of the Israeli left, were busy, but